packed lunch and the second at night for dinner, the halts being also used for topping up on water. Less than forty-eight hours later, we were at Ferozepur, where the tension was palpable with all indications of imminent hostilities. Here too everybody claimed that we had been allotted to them, so we were preparing to occupy defences one week and readying for an offensive the next. It was rather challenging to understand the situation and even more so to explain the new orders to the men almost daily. It did not exactly inspire us with much confidence.

This period of high alert lasted till about mid-February 1987, and it was only then that postings which had been held in abeyance were allowed. In a way, it was good that Veena had left earlier itself because, between her leaving and my posting, I had hardly stayed at Binaguri at all. In all this commotion, at least I knew she was safe and well-looked-after in Delhi. It was under such circumstances that I was given a hurried farewell 'dining out' and proceeded on posting to Fatehgarh, my first outing away from my paltan, my family.

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